The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Reuters

Donald Trump's "border czar", Tom Homan, said that federal immigration agents would end their operation in **Minnesota** after more than two months. The arrival of nearly 3,000 agents in the state sparked widespread protests which intensified after officers killed two American citizens. Mr Homan said the operation had been a "great success" in arresting "illegal aliens". American public opinion has turned against Mr Trump's deportation campaign.

CK **Hutchison**, a Hong Kong-based conglomerate, threatened legal action against Maersk should the Danish firm take control of two ports at either end of the **Panama Canal**. Last month Panama's Supreme Court cancelled CK Hutchison's contract to run the facilities; the government said a Maersk affiliate would temporarily take over. The court's decision was a boon to Mr Trump, who wants to limit China's sway over the canal.

Britain's top civil servant, Sir Chris Wormald, was forced out by the Labour government after barely a year in the job. He is the shortest-serving cabinet secretary since the post was created in 1916. Mr Wormald's departure will further destabilise **Sir Keir Starmer's** government. This week Sir Keir barely clung on to power after Labour colleagues threatened to turn against him.

WhatsApp said that Russia tried to “fully block” its services as part of a crackdown on foreign technology. The government banned other platforms owned by Meta, including Facebook and Instagram, in 2022; WhatsApp has continued to be Russia’s most popular messaging app with more than 100m users. The Kremlin wants Russians to switch to MAX, its own app with dodgy security.

Sanofi ousted its boss of six years, Paul Hudson. The French pharma giant has not developed as many successful new drugs as it had hoped to during his tenure. Several disappointed in late-stage trials. Mr Hudson will be replaced by Belén Garijo, who currently leads Merck, a German rival, and previously spent 15 years at the French firm. Shares in Sanofi fell by 5% on the news.

Nuveen, an American asset manager, agreed to buy **Schroders**, one of Britain’s oldest and most venerable fund managers, for $13.5bn. The combined firm will have $2.5trn of assets under management. The share price of Schroders has plunged in recent years as the company struggled to cut costs. Schroders said its 221-year-old brand would be retained.

Ukraine’s president, Volodymyr Zelensky, criticised the International Olympic Committee after it disqualified a Ukrainian skeleton rider at its 2026 Winter Games. Officials decided that Vladyslav Heraskevych’s wearing of a helmet that depicted athletes killed during Russia’s invasion broke competition rules. Mr Zelensky said the IOC should “not play into the hands of aggressors”.

Figure of the day: 99%, Brazil’s gross public debt as a percentage of its GDP, up from 62% in 2010. Read the full story.

Photograph: Getty Images

A democratic milestone in Bangladesh

On Thursday people in Bangladesh began voting in the country's first general election since Gen-Z protesters toppled Sheikh Hasina Wajed, the despotic prime minister, 18 months ago. It is the first competitive poll since the one that elected Sheikh Hasina in 2008. Two parties with long histories are going head to head: Jamaat-e-Islami, the largest and most moderate of Bangladesh's Islamist groups, and the Bangladesh Nationalist Party, led by Tarique Rahman, whose late mother and father both governed Bangladesh. Some of the student activists who helped throw out Sheikh Hasina are also running for seats in parliament.

Many voters are disappointed that Bangladesh's upheaval has not empowered new parties with bold and innovative agendas. The Islamists are probably less tolerant than they make out; the BNP's previous stints in power were marred by corruption. Still, Bangladesh has come a long way since its recent revolution.

Photograph: Reuters

Mixed tidings from Ukraine

Ukraine's new defence minister, Mykhailo Fedorov (pictured), will be bearing both bad and good news for his country's allies at the Ukraine Defence Contact Group which gathers in Brussels on Thursday. Mr Fedorov, a 35-year-old former tech entrepreneur, will make a desperate plea for more missile-defence interceptors. Russia has exploited the shortage by pummelling Ukraine's energy infrastructure with ballistic missiles, sometimes firing 30 in a salvo.

However, Russia also appears to be suffering a sharp rise in battlefield casualties for miniscule territory gains. Last year Russian forces advanced between 15 and 70 metres on average a day. As Michael Kofman, an American military analyst, puts it: "they are trading previous losses in equipment for much higher losses in personnel." He argues that even with its superior manpower and huge signing-on bonuses, Russia will eventually run out of "individuals for whom the money is worth it." That should poke some holes in Vladimir Putin's narrative of inevitable Russian victory.

Photograph: Reuters

The EU's old economic problems—and old solutions

Leaders of the European Union's 27 national governments will gather in a chateau in eastern Belgium on Thursday to brainstorm ways to enliven the bloc's listless economy. Concerns that Europe is falling behind America, and failing to keep up with Chinese innovation, are not new. But they have intensified of late because of Trumpian tariffs and European companies' insecure access to critical raw materials from China.

Leaders will discuss plans to make the single market work better for companies that want to do business across EU borders. One idea is to launch a new form of company, known as EU Inc, to enable entrepreneurs to seamlessly reach the EU's 450m consumers. France is promoting "buy-European" rules to give domestic suppliers priority when governments buy goods and services, especially in defence, digital and industrial sectors. But other countries, such as Sweden, denounce that idea as old-fashioned protectionism.

Illustration: David Simonds

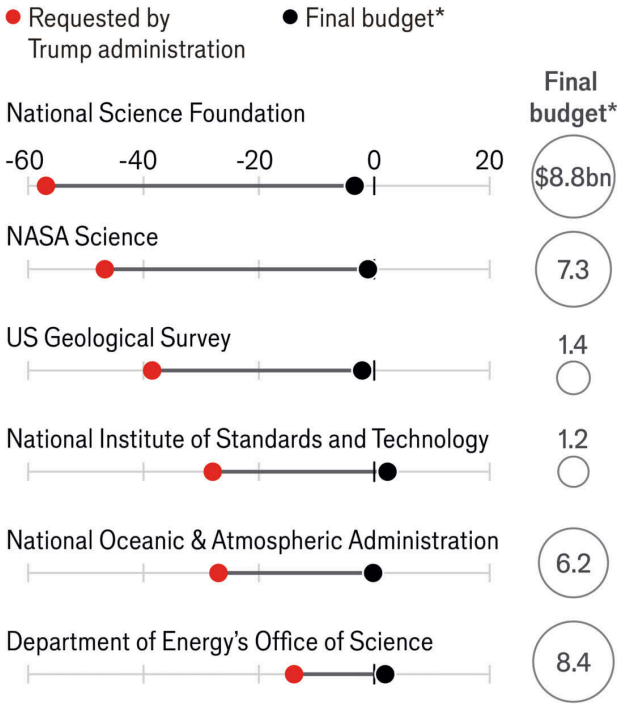
Science under siege in America

As the American Association for the Advancement of Science gathers in Phoenix, Arizona, on Thursday for its annual meeting, scientific matters will be jostling for attention with political ones. The complacent confidence with which scientists in America once viewed government support for their endeavours, regardless of who occupied the White House, has been shaken by an administration that dismisses and distrusts academia.

The Trump administration ignores the data in areas such as climatology. It cannot see the point of fields, such as planetary science, that are driven by curiosity rather than practical value. It has appointed a health secretary who seems to regard vaccines as the spawn of the devil rather than one of medicine's finest achievements. Though bipartisan support for science still exists in Congress, which recently pushed back on several proposed funding cuts, the mood at the AAAS is likely to be gloomy, as researchers discuss how to weather the storm.

Holding the line

US, budget proposals for selected science agencies, FY 2026, % change on year earlier



*After compromises between the House and Senate
Source: American Institute of Physics

Photograph: Virginie Surdej

The riches of Berlinale

The 76th International Berlin Film Festival opens on Thursday with “No Good Men”, an international co-production between Afghanistan, Germany, France, Norway and Denmark. Directed by Shahrbanoo Sadat, a young Afghan film-maker, it sheds light on the lives of women in her home country which she left in 2021 for Germany. Ms Sadat also plays the lead role of Naru, the only female camera-operator at Kabul TV, whose blossoming acquaintance with Quodrat, a reporter (played by Anwar Hashimi), changes her mind about Afghan men—just before the Taliban’s return.

More than 200 films, selected from 8,000 submissions, will follow with screenings across many of the festival’s cinemas until February 22nd. The competition’s line-up spans genres from satirical comedy to psychological thriller, and features “A New Dawn” a Japanese-French animation and “Yo (Love is a Rebellious Bird)”, an American documentary on love between an old and a young woman. The jury, headed by Wim Wenders, a German film-maker, as well as viewers are in for a treat.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: Who is currently fifth in line to the British throne?

Wednesday: Cymru is the alternative name for which nation, part of the UK?

The abstract kills, the concrete saves.

Sylvia Plath